

Underreported suicide

A DIGITAL survey conducted by Dawn on Pakistan's disturbing suicide rates in 2020 was published recently by a renowned research journal. A peer-reviewed paper, published in Taylor & Francis, uses the survey results to assess attitudes towards suicide. It concludes, based on the survey's findings, that mental illness tends to be recognized as a high likelihood contributor to suicide, and that most respondents consider suicide a way to "escape pain". It found that barriers to seeking help included social taboos, inaccessibility, and unaffordability. Women and youth are higher risk groups, though the status of rural Pakistanis remained unclear, as many respondents were from urban areas. Death by suicide in Pakistan is seen as a taboo subject and therefore grossly underreported. In the digital project, scores of respondents shared anonymously how they harbored suicidal thoughts or had lost a loved one to suicide. Of the 5,157 survey respondents, 38pc personally knew someone who has taken their own life. Around 9pc said they had tried to end their lives. These figures are astounding. Some data suggests that up to 35 people die by suicide in Pakistan every day, but owing to social taboos, poor record-keeping and the apathy of policymakers towards mental health issues, accurate data is scarce. The responses to the survey show a population crushed by social, financial and psychological burdens, with limited avenues of help. A suicide epidemiology expert, who saw the results, described them as a "window to the internal emotional struggles that so many Pakistanis are going through". The anonymous anecdotes from respondents show they are likely to hail from the middle- to upper-middle class sections. "But reading about their struggles also gives us a clue what the not so well off in our society must be going through," the expert noted.

Journalism in the public interest is critical, especially when it has an impact. While it is a matter of pride for this newspaper that its efforts form the basis of international suicide research, it is a pity that the subject of mental health often goes ignored by our own policymakers. At the end of 2022, efforts by the PPP led to the passage of a law that decriminalises suicide. Though challenged in court, it remains an important starting step, but a lot more must be done to address the mental health epidemic gripping the country.

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Changing times

FEW among the older generations seem to realize it now, but Pakistani politics has undergone a paradigm shift that has been little understood and sparsely commented upon. The proliferation of new mediums through which highly potent political narratives can be disseminated, shared, commented upon and augmented has brought about a sea change in how narrative battles are being and will be fought. Most of those who hold traditional power were oblivious as our politics was taking this evolutionary leap forward; meanwhile, Pakistan's largest demographic — its youth — experienced its political coming of age on social media. The authorities and strategic think tanks had woken up to the changing dynamics some years ago. However, they made the mistake of looking at it from the 'Fifth Generation Warfare' lens alone. The reality is far more complex, and is constantly being shaped by trends that rise and disappear quicker than they are being documented.

Take the PTI's success in dodging the overwhelming restrictions placed upon it, for example. Despite facing arrests, police crackdowns, censorship on traditional media, prohibitions on political gatherings, internet blockades, and the loss of its electoral symbol, the party has managed to remain competitive in the race for the Feb 8 election. From TikTok jalsas to live-streaming events on YouTube, AI-generated speeches to public 'spaces' on X, the party has consistently broken new ground while engaging a segment of the population traditionally considered jaded or disinterested in mainstream politics. It has managed to do so because it is perhaps the only political party that has proactively evolved for the digital age. Other parties have attempted to replicate its successes, but they seem well behind the curve. The state does not know what to do: threatening traditional media into subservience is easy and non-disruptive, choking the internet means severing the entire backbone of the modern economy.

Of course, social media right now is the Wild West of the internet. There is a mad rush with everyone attempting to seize a slice of the influence pie. It is also difficult to keep track of what is true, what is misinformation, and what is an outright lie. This poses serious risks that can and are causing unprecedented social instability. As users grow more aware, these risks will subside. One must also be careful in estimating any party's popularity or lack thereof based on its 'social media numbers' alone. However, while it seems easy now to deride someone by saying 'they will only form their government

on TikTok', for the generation of Pakistanis dreaming of life in the metaverse, social media is where all their information will eventually be produced and consumed. Therefore, other Pakistani political parties will have to catch up. Those which cannot will see their influence decline.

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Partial justice

IT is unfortunate that, on Friday, the International Court of Justice did not endorse South Africa's demand for an immediate cessation of hostilities in Gaza as it delivered a preliminary ruling on the genocide case brought against Israel.

While legal intricacies are important, stopping the butchery of Palestinians is a more pressing concern. However, the court has upped the moral pressure on Tel Aviv to end its amoral campaign against defenceless civilians in the besieged Strip, even though the Zionist state has no intention of doing so.

Importantly, the judges felt that South Africa's evidence supporting the genocide case against Israel could not be ruled out "prima facie". Furthermore, the bench ordered Tel Aviv to take all possible measures to prevent acts of genocide, prevent and punish those involved in the incitement of genocide, and ensure the delivery of humanitarian aid to Gaza. Israel has been given a month to report back to The Hague with regard to complying with these measures.

In his reaction, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has termed the order "outrageous" and vowed to continue fighting his "just war" in which some 26,000 people have been massacred. Earlier, he had boasted: "Nobody will stop us — not The Hague... ."

Meanwhile, the US that has lent its iron-clad support to Tel Aviv, which is responsible for a massacre that will go down in infamy, has said it continues to believe "allegations of genocide are unfounded". Though it may take the ICJ years to determine if, legally, Israel's actions in Gaza constitute genocide, in the popular view the murder of children, the collective punishment and starvation of an entire civilian population, and the ethnic cleansing of Gazans very much fit the definition of genocide. Other states have hailed the ICJ's order.

Where to from here? Most importantly, when will the slaughter of Gaza's people end? While the ICJ's rulings are binding, the court cannot enforce them. And as Israel's arrogant replies have proved, it has no intention of respecting the court's orders. This is a mockery of the very rules-based order the US, UK and other Western states have sworn to uphold.

In the past, these actors have bombed, or threatened to attack states that have, according to them, strayed from the 'rules-based order'. Will they take a similar line against Israel? Or will they continue to defend the indefensible? Kudos to South Africa for raising a voice for humanity and against barbarism, irrespective of religious and ethnic affiliations. It is hoped that when the court next meets, more concrete measures are proposed to end the bloodbath and that one day, those responsible for shedding the blood of innocents in Gaza are brought to justice, as are those who aided and abetted them.

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